



Tracing the Central Idea

Grade 8 • North Carolina • Reading

RI.8.2

Determine a central idea of an informational text, analyze how supporting ideas develop it across the text, and write an objective summary. An 80-minute block-period packet with warm-up, guided practice, partner discussion, independent practice, small-group work, and a full answer key.

PRINT • TEACH • REVISIT



Plan the 80-minute block

Level and alignment

Grade 8 · North Carolina · Reading; RI.8.2 — Determine a central idea of a text and analyze its development over the course of the text, including its relationship to supporting ideas; provide an objective summary of the text.

What is included

Cover; teacher guide; vocabulary and lesson preview; original passage; warm-up (2 items); guided practice with organizer (4 items); partner discussion (3 items); independent practice (6 items); small-group intervention and enrichment (4 items); exit ticket; complete answer key; access and sources page.

Suggested pacing (80 minutes)

Warm-up 8 min · passage + guided practice 25 min · partner discussion 12 min · independent practice 20 min · small-group work 10 min · exit ticket 5 min.

Preparation

Print student pages separately from the answer key. Review the passage and organizer before class. No outside novel or paid app required.

Student directions

Read the passage carefully. Use evidence from the text to support every answer. Quote or closely paraphrase the text and name the paragraph.



Before you read

Key vocabulary

Lesson focus

A central idea is the main point an informational text develops, not just its topic. Supporting ideas are the smaller points, facts, or examples that build and refine the central idea as the text progresses. At grade 8, tracing development means showing how specific supporting ideas connect to and strengthen the central idea from one part of the text to another, not just restating the topic.

Model 1 — Topic: a city's new recycling program. Write a possible central idea as a full sentence, and name one type of supporting idea (a fact, statistic, or example) that might develop it.

A possible central idea: "A city's new recycling program succeeded because it made participation easy for residents." A supporting idea could be a statistic showing participation rates before and after curbside bins were introduced.

Model 2 — Is "the program collected 40 percent more recyclable material in its second year" an objective summary sentence or an opinion? Explain.

It is objective — it reports a specific, verifiable statistic without added judgment; a subjective version might add a word like "impressively" or "finally."



WARM-UP

Warm-up · Before you read

Answer using what you already know. Five minutes.

1. What explicit statistic does paragraph 1 give about the market's weekly visitors by 2024?

2. What is the central idea stated explicitly in paragraph 1?



From Empty Lot to Open Market: How Two Neighbors Started Riverbend's Saturday Market (Part 1)

In 2019, the corner of Fifth and Poplar in Riverbend was an empty gravel lot used mostly for overflow parking during football games. By 2024, the same lot hosted a Saturday market drawing over 2,000 visitors a week and generating an estimated \$340,000 a year for more than thirty small vendors. The central idea behind that change was simple: a market succeeds when it removes the specific barriers that keep small vendors from selling in the first place.

2. The market began with two neighbors, Elena Vasquez and Tom Okafor, who ran small food businesses out of their homes but could not afford the vendor fees at the region's established farmers markets, which ranged from \$75 to \$150 per weekend. Vasquez and Okafor surveyed twelve other home-based sellers in Riverbend and found the same complaint from all twelve: high fees, not lack of demand, were keeping them from selling in public.

3. Their first solution addressed that exact barrier. They approached the city about using the empty lot for free on Saturdays, arguing that an unused gravel lot generated zero tax revenue anyway. The city agreed to a six-month trial, waiving fees entirely and asking only that vendors carry basic liability insurance, which Vasquez and Okafor arranged as a discounted group policy for \$40 a year per vendor.



From Empty Lot to Open Market: How Two Neighbors Started Riverbend's Saturday

Market (Part 2)

The second barrier they identified was visibility: even vendors who could afford to sell had no easy way to tell customers where or when. Vasquez built a simple text-alert list, and Okafor designed hand-painted signs for the five streets leading into the neighborhood. In the trial's first month, twelve vendors participated; by the sixth month, the number had grown to twenty-six, entirely by word of mouth and the text list, with no paid advertising.

5. The third barrier surfaced only after the market was running: inconsistent hours. Some vendors opened at 8 a.m., others at 10, and customers who arrived expecting a full market sometimes found half the stalls empty. The market's informal vendor council, formed by the participants themselves in month four, voted to require a fixed 9 a.m. to 1 p.m. window for any vendor wanting a reserved spot.

6. By the end of the six-month trial, the city's own data showed average Saturday foot traffic on Fifth and Poplar had risen from near zero to just over 2,000 visitors, and the city extended the arrangement indefinitely, still without vendor fees. Vasquez and Okafor now spend roughly five hours a week coordinating the market, work they describe as unpaid but far less time-consuming than the fee negotiations they used to face at other markets.

7. Neither Vasquez nor Okafor has since raised a fee. When a city council member suggested a small fee to fund market improvements in 2023, the vendor council voted it down, 19 to 4, and instead proposed a voluntary \$5 monthly contribution, which about half the vendors currently pay.

Guided practice · Evidence organizer

Work through this organizer together before independent practice.

It Says Quote or closely paraphrase the text.	It Means Explain the evidence in your own words.	And So State the inference or analysis it supports.

1. What explicit barrier does paragraph 2 identify through the survey of twelve home-based sellers?

2. How does the fee-waiver solution in paragraph 3 directly support the central idea from paragraph 1?

3. What second barrier does paragraph 4 introduce, and how is it different from the fee barrier in paragraph 2?

4. What explicit statistic in paragraph 4 shows the visibility solution's effect on vendor participation?

Partner discussion

Discuss each question with a partner before writing a joint response.

1. How does the vendor growth statistic in paragraph 4 develop the central idea further than the fee-waiver alone could?

2. What third barrier does paragraph 5 identify, and who solved it?

3. Why is it significant for the central idea that the vendor council, not the city, solved the hours problem in paragraph 5?



Independent practice

Work independently. Cite evidence from the text in every answer.

1. What explicit data does paragraph 6 give about foot traffic by the end of the trial?

2. How does paragraph 7's vote result (19 to 4) support the central idea established across the article?

3. Which supporting idea most strongly develops the central idea: the fee waiver, the text-alert system, or the fixed hours rule? Justify your choice.



Independent practice

Work independently. Cite evidence from the text in every answer.

4. Explain how paragraphs 2 through 5 are organized to support the central idea, using the word "barrier" in your answer.

5. Write one objective sentence summarizing paragraphs 2 and 3 (no opinions).

6. Identify one word in this draft summary that is an opinion, not a fact: "The founders cleverly solved the visibility problem with simple, effective signs."



Small-group work

Use with students who need additional support.

1. Write an objective one-sentence summary of paragraphs 6 and 7.

2. Why would "the market grew because Riverbend residents love supporting local business" be an inappropriate central-idea statement for this article?

Small-group work

Use with students ready for additional challenge.

1. Combine paragraphs 1, 4, and 6 into a two-sentence objective summary tracing the central idea's development.

2. What explicit detail from paragraph 2 shows the founders based their solution on evidence rather than a guess?



Exit ticket

Answer independently to show what you learned today.

1. Trace the central idea's development across the entire article, citing at least three supporting ideas in the order they appear.



Exit ticket · self-assessment

Rate today's work:

4 — I can teach this to someone else.

3 — I can do this independently.

2 — I can do this with help.

1 — I need to revisit this with my teacher.



Answer key

1. Over 2,000 visitors a week.
2. A market succeeds when it removes the specific barriers that keep small vendors from selling in the first place.
3. High vendor fees at established farmers markets, ranging from \$75 to \$150 per weekend, not a lack of customer demand.
4. It removes the specific barrier (high fees) identified in paragraph 2, directly matching the central idea that removing barriers, not simply creating a market, is what leads to vendor participation.
5. The second barrier is visibility — customers not knowing where or when the market operated — which is different because it affects whether customers show up, not whether vendors can afford to participate.

Accept equivalent, well-supported alternative answers throughout.



Answer key

6. Vendor participation grew from twelve in the trial's first month to twenty-six by the sixth month.
7. It shows that removing one barrier (fees) was not enough by itself; solving the visibility barrier was also necessary for participation to keep growing, extending the central idea to include more than one kind of barrier.
8. Inconsistent vendor hours; the market's own informal vendor council, formed by the participants themselves, solved it by setting a fixed 9 a.m. to 1 p.m. window.
9. It shows the barrier-removal approach extends to self-organization among vendors, not just outside city support, reinforcing that identifying and removing a specific barrier — regardless of who removes it — is what drives success.
10. Foot traffic rose from near zero to just over 2,000 visitors a week.

Accept equivalent, well-supported alternative answers throughout.



Answer key

11. The vendor council's strong vote against a new fee shows their continued belief that removing financial barriers, the very first barrier identified, remains central to the market's success, even years later.

12. The fee waiver most strongly develops the central idea, because it was the original barrier identified through the founders' survey and the direct basis for the central idea stated in paragraph 1; the other two solved barriers that emerged only after the market already existed.

13. The paragraphs are organized as a sequence of barriers and their removal — fees, then visibility, then inconsistent hours — each paragraph identifying one specific barrier and the corresponding solution, which builds the central idea point by point rather than stating it once.

14. Vasquez and Okafor surveyed other home-based sellers, found that high vendor fees were the main barrier to selling, and arranged a fee-free trial with the city along with discounted liability insurance.

15. "Cleverly" and "effective" are opinions about the quality of the solution, not neutral facts from the text.

Accept equivalent, well-supported alternative answers throughout.



Answer key

16. By the end of the trial, foot traffic had risen to over 2,000 visitors and the city extended the fee-free arrangement, which the vendor council later voted to keep by rejecting a proposed fee in 2023.

17. It is not supported as the article's central idea; the article specifically attributes the market's growth to the identification and removal of concrete barriers (fees, visibility, hours), not to general community sentiment, which the text never measures or claims.

18. An empty gravel lot became a Saturday market after its founders identified and removed the specific barriers keeping small vendors from selling, starting with high fees and later addressing visibility. Vendor participation and customer foot traffic both grew steadily as each barrier was addressed, reaching over 2,000 weekly visitors by the end of the trial.

19. They surveyed twelve other home-based sellers and found the same complaint from all twelve, which grounded their solution in direct evidence rather than assumption.

20. The central idea — that removing specific barriers drives a market's success — develops first through the fee waiver (paragraph 3), then through the visibility solutions of a text list and signage (paragraph 4), then through the vendor council's fixed-hours rule (paragraph 5), each addressing a different barrier the community had actually identified.

Accept equivalent, well-supported alternative answers throughout.



Access, sources, and license

AIG

Ask for a second interpretation, a counterexample, or a student-written item at the same rigor, with an explanation of the choice.

504

Follow the individual plan: extended time, breaks, enlarged print, reduced copying, or an alternate response method as documented.

EC

Pre-teach key vocabulary before reading. Model the first guided-practice item aloud. Accept oral or dictated responses when appropriate.

ESL

Preview key vocabulary with examples. Allow brief home-language discussion before independent writing. Provide sentence starters for open-response items.

Official alignment source · accessed September 18, 2026

RI.8.2 — Determine a central idea of a text and analyze its development over the course of the text, including its relationship to supporting ideas; provide an objective summary of the text.. The objective is original wording describing a focused part of the standard.

NC ELA Standard Course of Study, Grade 8: <https://www.thecorestandards.org/ELA-Literacy/RI/8/2/>

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